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Bush outreach runs on persistence, charm

He emphasizes working together

By Anne E. Kornblut
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — President Bush's movie date with Senator Edward M. Kennedy Thursday night was a sign of the affinity of the two political opposites. But as Bush embarked on a campaign to court the Democratic Party this weekend, Kennedy's White House visit also served as a symbol of presidential pragmatism.

When bringing Kennedy into the Oval Office on Thursday night, Bush displayed a keen awareness of the senator's relationship to the famous room, sources familiar with the visit said.

The two men focused on the desk that once belonged to John F. Kennedy, with Bush telling the Massachusetts senator how he had requested the late president's famous desk to use as his own. They bantered about how they had both spent time in the White House before, a tacit acknowledgment of their family ties to the presidency.

During a visit that lasted more than four hours, Bush and Kennedy also discussed some legislative priorities, part of a running dialogue that has taken place through four face-to-face encounters in the last two weeks. Over hamburgers and ribs and a screening of the movie "Thirteen Days," an account of President Kennedy's handling of the Cuban Missile Crisis, Bush continued a charm offensive that has at times appeared to be more focused on Kennedy than any other Democrat.

The dinner-and-a-movie date took place as Bush embarked on a two-day campaign to try to work his magic on dozens of political opponents. Yesterday, Bush appeared at the annual closed-door retreat for Senate Democrats, a visit the White House spokesman called "unprecedented." On Sunday he will visit House Democrats at their retreat at a swank resort near Pittsburgh.

When speaking to the group of Democratic senators at the Library of Congress yesterday, Bush told of how he had once singled out another legendary Democrat to become his ally. In Texas, Bush recalled, his most significant alliance was with former lieutenant governor Bob Bullock, a powerful force in the Legislature who had rejected Bush's initial overtures but later came to support him, even asking Bush, from his deathbed, to deliver the eulogy at his funeral.

"That's a lesson I carry with me," Bush said.

The president's personal appeal has done little to quiet Democratic objections to numerous White House decisions affecting policy, particularly the appointment of former Missouri senator John Ashcroft as attorney general. Hours before he arrived with his family for their 8:44 p.m. appointment to see Bush, Kennedy rounded out his vehement opposition to Ashcroft by casting his ballot against the president's nominee. He was one of 42 Democrats to oppose Ashcroft's confirmation.

Likewise, House minority leader Richard A. Gephardt, who two days earlier received a 60th birthday cake personally delivered by Laura Bush, yesterday sent Bush a letter that is almost certain to spark controversy. Gephardt, a Missouri Democrat, asked Bush to renominate Judge Ronnie White to the federal bench.

President Clinton's nomination of White, the first African-American judge on the Missouri Supreme Court, was blocked after a campaign by Ashcroft, who said he had concerns that White was soft on crime. Though he had supported other black judicial nominees, Ashcroft was later accused of being racially biased.

White House officials said last night they had not yet received Gephardt's letter.

Bush may also find his efforts at bipartisanship stalled next week, when he is scheduled to send his $1.6 trillion tax cut plan to Congress. Unlike most of his legislative proposals unveiled over the last two weeks, such as his initiatives on education and faith-based charities, the tax cut plan is opposed by some Democrats who believe it is too large, though support has grown in recent weeks.

So far, Democrats, especially Kennedy, have appeared adept at functioning on two tracks: opposing Bush at the policy level while remaining civil, even friendly, in person.

Bush has demonstrated a similar skill. Even after the hostility he faced from Democrats over Ashcroft, Bush adopted a sunny pose, telling senators he hoped to "rid the system of rancor."

Tomorrow, in his visit to the House Democrats, Bush hopes to encourage them to "focus less on bickering and more on working," his press secretary said. Bush has met with more than 150 members of Congress in the 13 days since taking office, according to the White House.

Bush "hopes that by going to the retreats of the other parties, as well, of course, as his own party, . . . people across the country will see our government works together well," said White House press secretary Ari Fleischer.



AP PHOTO

Attorney General John Ashcroft meeting FBI Director Louis Freeh at the Justice Department during Ashcroft's first day on the job. Last night President Bush watched a movie with Ashcroft critic Edward M. Kennedy, in an effort for greater bipartisanship.

Kennedy war chest full for 2006

Massachusetts delegation reports funds

By Glen Johnson
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Last anyone doubt Senator Edward M. Kennedy's interest in remaining in Congress six years hence, he declared his candidacy for 2006 even before beginning his latest term last month.

The Massachusetts Democrat signed a statement of candidacy on Dec. 6, less than a month after being elected to his seventh full term. The form was filed with the secretary of the Senate on Dec. 18. Kennedy had told the Globe in September 1999 that he would seek reelection in 2006.

A spokesman said the 68-year-old Kennedy declared his candidacy anew because he had no campaign debt and contributions continued to arrive. A would-be contender must sign such a statement once he receives in excess of $5,000.

Even six years out, Kennedy already has more money on hand than most active candidates. He also has more than seven times as much as the state's junior senator, John F. Kerry, who is up for reelection in two years.

According to campaign finance reports filed this week, Kennedy ended last year with $3.96 million cash on hand. By contrast, Kerry ended with $526,000.

In a recent interview, Kerry said he was happy with the total because, for the first time in his reelection campaigns, he can begin without debt from a previous race.

Kerry's fund-raising is expected to bloom over the next two years, thanks to an active campaign, his recent addition to the Senate Finance Committee, and speculation that he may run for the Democratic presidential nomination in 2004.

Just this week, Kerry was spotted on Capitol Hill walking with Michael Whouley, a Boston political consultant who most recently served as a top adviser to former Vice President Al Gore. The senator's staff said the two were old friends who were simply catching up.

Among the 10 Massachusetts House members, the reports served as testament to the power of incumbency. Half of the all-Democratic delegation had no opposition in November, so they used the election cycle to build their accounts. Even some of those with opponents did the same.

Representative Martin T. Meehan of Lowell ended the year with $1.97 million cash on hand, the most among those whose reports were on file with the Federal Election Commission as of yesterday afternoon. They had to be postmarked by Wednesday.

Meehan, said to be considering a future run for governor or the US Senate, had more than double in the bank than his colleagues.

Representative William D. Delahunt of Quincy was second in terms of free cash, with $1.04 million. Representative Richard E. Neal of Springfield was third with $926,000, followed by Edward J. Markey of Malden with $780,000, J. Joseph Moakley of South Boston with $540,000, Barney E. Frank of Newton with $131,000, and John W. Olver of Amherst, who ended the year with $126,000 in free cash.

Of those reporting, only Olver and Markey spent more than they raised over the course of the year. Olver, who had two opponents, raised $383,000 for the year while spending $408,000. Markey, who was unopposed, raised $118,000 while spending $165,000.

Moakley, who had two opponents, raised $693,000 while spending $670,000. Frank, who also had two opponents, raised $308,000 while spending $158,000. Delahunt, who had a lone opponent, raised $319,000 while spending a relatively paltry $75,000 during the year.

Meehan, who was unopposed, raised $618,000 and spent $268,000, while Neal, also unopposed, raised $407,000 and spent $233,000. Many of the Democrats distributed funds to colleagues and Democratic candidates who had tighter races.

Black leaders ponder unexpected puzzle of Bush presidency

► RACE
Continued from A1

cesses, as well other groups. Nor has he been blind to the achievements of black America.

When troops mass ominously in some faraway place, it will be a black woman, National Security Adviser Condoleezza Rice, who gives the word to alert the president. When the men and women who represent the nations of the world gather to discuss war and peace, America's face will be that of a black man, Secretary of State Colin Powell. The cornerstone of Bush's domestic policy will be overseen by Education Secretary Roderick Paige, a black educator.

"These are signs that are very positive," said former Baltimore Mayor Kurt Schmoke.

Rice, Powell, and Paige now preside at the kind of meetings where blacks once only served. And since taking office, Bush has followed up his appointments with a series of gestures that include visits to black churches and schools, his faith-based and education policy initiatives and conversations like the one he held with the black caucus Wednesday, with Jesse Jackson and other African-American leaders.

"He fully realizes there's work to do," said Scott McClellan, Bush's deputy press secretary. "When he was governor, his support [among black Texans] went from 18 percent [in his first run for office] to 27 percent in his run for reelection. The president has a proven record of reaching out to people from all walks of life."

The Bush charm offensive has caught wary black leaders by surprise and left them with questions: Do they put stock in his pledge to carry out election reform? Do they believe that health care coverage will be expanded and education improved? Do they try to meet Bush half way? Or do they risk marginalizing themselves in implacable opposition?

"We're in a very interesting situation," Cummings said. "We have a lot of our constituents who believe he should not be president; he didn't win. But there are people who pay taxes and try to send their kids to college. We've got to represent them."

Bush pledged during the campaign to be a "uniter, not a divider," but black leaders remember how he refused to call for the removal of the Confederate flag from the State House dome in South Carolina and how he spoke at Bob Jones University, which, until last year, banned interracial dating. As a congressman, Vice President Dick Cheney voted against imposing sanctions on the apartheid government of South Africa. And Ashcroft opposed a federal desegregation case as Missouri's attorney general.

Do blacks have faith that the new president wants to "do the right thing" when it comes to their interests?

"Absolutely not," said Representative Donald M. Payne, Democrat of New Jersey, a former chairman of the black caucus.

"Maybe we can get some good trade-offs," said Representative Major R. Owens, a Democrat from New York. "Beyond that, I think we'll get little done that's important to black folks."

"There is a trust gap," acknowledged Mayor Lee Brown of Houston, a Democrat who knows and likes the president.

The bar for black support of the Republican Party wasn't always so high. Abraham Lincoln's Emancipation Proclamation created a reservoir of good will that wasn't tapped out until Franklin Roosevelt captured the White House in 1932, and John Kennedy and Lyndon Johnson endorsed the cause of civil rights in the 1960s. Republicans did lasting damage to their party's reputation in the black community by joining Southern Democrats to fight integration.

Dan Carter, a history professor at the University of South Carolina who has written a book about the role of race in political conservatism, thinks that Bush and other Republicans recognize that divisive appeals are out of fashion in an increasingly centrist, multicultural society.

"What Bush has decided is [that] he does have to sound conciliatory," Carter said. "If he doesn't, he risks alienating moderate white voters."

From 1936 through 1996, Republican candidates averaged just under 30 percent of the black vote, according to the Joint Center for Political and Economic Studies, a Washington, D.C., think tank. If Bush can't nudge the percentage of blacks who vote Republican back up toward that margin, then GOP gubernatorial and congressional candidates could be in trouble in 2002.

"I don't think we will ever see the Republican Party get 50 percent of the black vote," said Representative J.C. Watts Jr., a black Republican from Oklahoma. "But we surely ought to be doing better than 10 percent.

"I think Bush's challenge is to work around the gatekeepers and go directly to the people," said Watts, the chairman of the House Republican Conference. He noted how the NAACP and other black organizations used volleys of televised ads to attack Bush in the 2000 campaign.

He acknowledged: "Republicans don't talk about civil rights a whole lot, and I think that is a mistake."

Watts said the Bush administration should end the police practice of racial profiling. But he also thinks that blacks should stop using race as a crutch. "We cry wolf so much it actually hurts the cases where there is racism," he said.

At least one group of black ministers, including the Rev. Eugene Rivers of Dorchester, is intent on testing Bush's sincerity.

Rivers was one of several black pastors who met with Bush in Austin, Texas, on Dec. 20. A month later, Rivers traveled to Washington, D.C., to urge black voters to give the new administration a chance. He was back again this week, when Bush announced the details of a faith-based program to redress social problems.

"Our bottom line is to move beyond any discussion of personality and move to outcomes and policy," Rivers said.

Kenneth Blackwell, a black Republican who is Ohio's secretary of state, said Bush can gain black support through the voucher program he is offering as part of his education initiative.

"Many in the black community already support some form of school choice," Blackwell said. "President Bush needs to let them know he is on their side."

The goal, said Watts, "is for all parents, even poor families, to be able to send their children to an educational environment that works."

"Rich people are already getting their kids out of bad schools," he said.

Pursuing vouchers would put Bush squarely against the Congressional Black Caucus, whose members told the president Wednesday night that they don't support the idea. The two sides agreed to disagree, a theme that's likely to play out repeatedly.

Nor did the Powell, Rice, and Paige appointments make an immediate impact in the public opinion polls, which continue to show a high level of mistrust for Bush among blacks.

"While it looks like steps have been taken to open the door to blacks, it seems like it's only to certain ones," said Ken Granderson, an African-American who is chief executive officer of Inner-City Software in Dorchester.

Unlike President Clinton, who grew up among blacks in Arkansas, Bush has a limited base of familiarity to draw upon in his dealings with African-Americans. Yet Houston Mayor Brown, a Democrat, said Bush's personality may eventually prove winning.

"He's a very down-to-earth person, very friendly," Brown said. "It's my hope that he'll reach out."

The black vote for Republicans

Richard Nixon in 1960 was the last Republican presidential candidate to receive much support from African-Americans. Only Barry Goldwater in 1964 received a lower percentage of the black vote than George W. Bush.

Year	GOP candidate/Dem opponent	Percentage of black vote for GOP
1936	Landon /Roosevelt	22%
1940	Willkie/Roosevelt	32%
1944	Dewey/Roosevelt	32%
1948	Dewey/Truman	23%
1952	Eisenhower/Stevenson	24%
1956	Eisenhower/Stevenson	39%
1960	Nixon/Kennedy	32%
1964	Goldwater/Johnson	6%
1968	Nixon/Humphrey	13%
1972	Nixon/McGovern	13%
1976	Ford/Carter	13%
1980	Reagan/Carter	12%
1984	Reagan/Mondale	9%
1988	G.H.W. Bush/Dukakis	12%
1992	G.H.W. Bush /Clinton	11%
1996	Dole/Clinton	12%
2000	G.W. Bush/Gore	8%

SOURCES: Based on polling data compiled by the Joint Center for Political and Economic Studies

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